

LOADING THE FORTRESS

American ground crew load the bombs on to a Boeing B-17E Flying Fortress. The B-17's normal bombload of around 6,000lb (2,700kg) was about half that of an RAF Lancaster, making the B-17, in British terms, a medium rather than heavy bomber.

down and another 11 so badly damaged on their return that they were written off to be cannibalized for spare parts. It is a tribute to the courage and commitment of American aircrews that they held steady in the face of such losses.

Bombing routine

The routine of a US Eighth Air Force bomber operation started early. The men would be roused at around 2:00am by an operations officer snapping on the light in their hut and calling off the crews that were to fly on the day's mission. They stumbled out into the darkness of

a raw East Anglian night to walk to a briefing session, where the announcement of the target for the day, almost inevitably deep inside Germany, was greeted with a traditional groan and cursing. By 4:00am the aircrews were eating breakfast, if they had the stomach for it, while ground crews swarmed over the B-17s readying and loading them for the mission. An hour later the airmen would be in the dispersal tent by their aircraft, waiting for the red flare from the control tower that meant "start engines." Although each member of the crew meticulously carried out the practical preparations for his role on the mission, most also carried a lucky coin or a love letter about their person – faced with the lottery of death, superstition flourished.

The "Forts" took off at 30-second intervals, lifting off sluggishly, loaded with around 50 bombs, 2,500 gallons (9,500 liters) of fuel, and heavy crates of ammunition for the guns. Then the ball-turret gunner climbed into his position and at 10,000ft (3,500m) the crew went on to oxygen, while the aircraft continued climbing, taking up its place in the formation. Setting off for Germany, the bombers were an awesome sight. A pilot recalled his "exhilaration and pride" at the spectacle: "The great battle formations were something to see! As far as the eye could see there were B-17s, some of them olive-drab Fs, others the new silver Gs." The flight was cold and uncomfortable, especially for the ball-turret gunner suspended in space with his knees pulled up almost to his chest.

Facing the flak

As soon as the day bombers were beyond the range of fighter escort, they came under attack from swarms of German fighters, mostly Bf 109s and Focke-Wulf Fw 190s. Discomfort and cold were immediately forgotten as the terror and excitement took over. The Luftwaffe pilots assigned to defense of the fatherland were the cream of the service and quite undeterred by the bombers' bristling guns. They often attacked head-on, trying to break up the bomber formation and exploiting the lack of armor and armament on the B-17's nose. Or they would launch beam attacks, raking the bombers with machine-gun and cannon fire as they cut across them. Gunners blazed away as the German aircraft buzzed around the formation. Soon parachutes would be peppering the sky as airmen jumped from their burning B-17s; some Fortresses exploded in midair, giving the crews no chance of escape.

Approaching the target, inevitably through heavy flak, the bombardier and his Norden bombsight took over control of the B-17 from the pilot. Holding straight and steady on the run into the target was essential to bombing accuracy, but

